MODULE 5

The most expensive communication problem in healthcare management isn't saying the wrong thing.

It's burying the right thing in so much context that the point gets lost entirely.

If your audience has to work to find your point, they will stop working — and stop listening.

- SCQA: Situation → Complication → Question → Answer. In that order.
- The Pyramid Principle: your recommendation first. Three supporting reasons. Then evidence.
- Building to your point signals that you aren't fully committed to it. Leading with it signals confidence.

KEY INSIGHT
The next time you walk into a meeting to make a case for something, open with the answer. Everything else is support.

The managers who advance communicate proactively. The ones who wait until they're asked remain operational.

- BLUF: Bottom Line Up Front. One sentence. If it takes two, it's not ready.
- Four pitfalls: over-reporting, under-reporting, problem dumping, approval-seeking.
- Bringing a problem without a proposed solution is asking leadership to do your job for you.

KEY INSIGHT
When you bring something to your administrator, do you arrive with a recommendation — or a question?

There's a difference between reporting what the numbers are and telling people what the numbers mean.

- A dashboard full of metrics without a headline finding is a collection of data, not a presentation.
- The Headline Test: write one sentence that states what the data means — not what it shows.
- Every data presentation should end with a decision or recommendation. Not a summary.

KEY INSIGHT
What is the data story in your practice right now that leadership most needs to hear? Have you told it?

The performance issue you haven't addressed directly is already affecting your team — whether or not you've said anything.

- SBI Model: Situation, Behavior, Impact. Behavioral specificity, not character judgment.
- Write the opening sentence in full before the conversation. Say it aloud. This step reduces avoidance significantly.
- The cost of avoidance compounds every week. Calculate what six months of delay has cost.

KEY INSIGHT
What is the most important conversation you haven't had yet? How long has it been not-happening?

Every email you send is making a professional impression. The question is whether it's the one you intend.

- Six decision points before sending: channel, subject line, structure, length, tone, timing.
- Your first sentence should be your point or your ask. Never make the reader search for your purpose.
- Read the email from the recipient's perspective before you send. What does it signal about you?

KEY INSIGHT
If your administrator read every significant email you sent this week, what would they conclude about how you think?

FRAMEWORK

SCQA — The Structure That Makes Communication Land

Four elements, in this order, transform a rambling briefing into a compelling one.

1. Situation: the shared context the audience already knows to be true.
2. Complication: why the situation is no longer acceptable or is creating tension.
3. Question: what the audience is now implicitly asking as a result.
4. Answer: your recommendation — stated clearly, directly, and first.
5. Test: if you removed everything except your Answer, would your audience still know what you're recommending? If not, clarify the Answer.

REFLECT ON THIS

Your communication structure signals how clearly you think.

Think of the last time a briefing or proposal you made didn't land the way you intended. Was it a content problem or a structure problem?

TRY THIS

Three communication actions for this week:

1. Use SCQA to structure one significant communication. Note how differently it lands.
2. Write the opening sentence for the difficult conversation you've been postponing. Say it aloud.
3. Before your next data update to leadership, write a one-sentence headline. What does the data mean?

The Focused Leader

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